Burnout



Burnout is a psychological syndrome that results from prolonged exposure to chronic, unmanaged workplace stress. Since 2019, the World Health Organization (WHO) has classified burnout in the International Classification of Diseases (ICD-11) as an "occupational phenomenon" not a medical condition, but a factor that influences health status.

Symptoms

Physical symptoms:

- **Chronic fatigue and low energy, even after rest**
- **Headaches, digestive issues, sleep disturbances**
- **Weakened immune system and frequent illness**

Psychological/emotional symptoms:

- **Feelings of emptiness, hopelessness, or being trapped**
- **Cynicism toward work, colleagues, or the profession as a whole**
- **Reduced motivation and a sense of meaninglessness at work**
- **Irritability and reduced tolerance**

Behavioral symptoms:

- **Decline in performance and productivity**
- **Avoidance of responsibilities, procrastination**
- **Social withdrawal from colleagues**
- **Increased use of caffeine, alcohol, or other substances to cope**

Conceptual background: The term "burnout" was first introduced by psychologist Herbert Freudenberger in 1974, when he observed a state of exhaustion in staff at volunteer clinics. However, it was Christina Maslach who turned the concept into a serious field of research.

Physiological mechanism: Burnout isn't merely a mental state chronic stress disrupts the HPA axis (hypothalamic–pituitary–adrenal axis). Under normal conditions, cortisol is released in response to stress and returns to baseline once the threat has passed. In chronic burnout, however, this system becomes "dysregulated": some studies have found lower-than-normal morning cortisol levels in individuals with severe burnout (a phenomenon similar to what is also observed in post-traumatic stress disorder).

The JD-R Model (Job Demands-Resources): Another widely used scientific framework is the Job Demands-Resources model, which holds that burnout occurs when job demands (workload, time pressure, role conflict) consistently outweigh available resources (autonomy, social support, feedback, growth opportunities). Unlike the MBI, which is more descriptive, this model has stronger predictive and intervention-oriented value, making it especially useful in organizational consulting.